

REBEL WITHOUT A PAUSE

Bhagat Singh's execution sounded the death knell for the British Raj



WITHOUT FEAR: THE LIFE AND TRIAL OF BHAGAT SINGH
by KULDIP NAYAR
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 395; Pages: 244

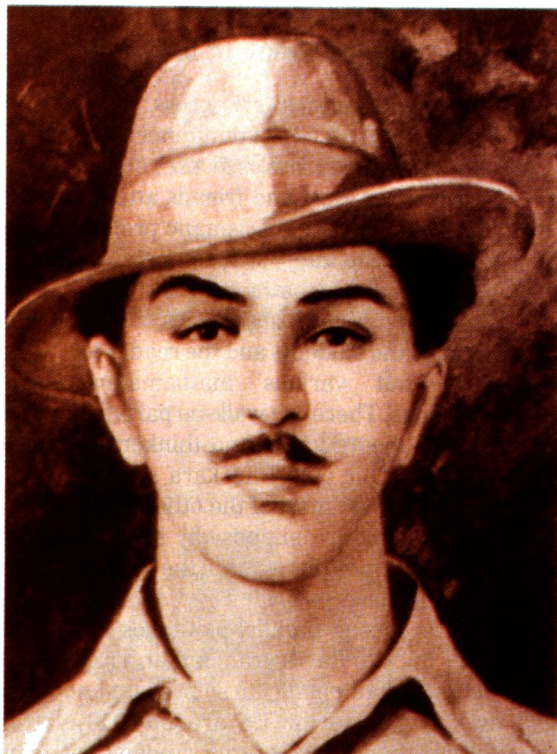
■ By Gillian Wright

Mahatma Gandhi wrote, "There has never been, within living memory, so much romance round any life as has surrounded that of Bhagat Singh." Kuldip Nayar's *Bhagat Singh* is indeed the stuff legends are made of. Revolution was fed to him with his mother's milk. His father and uncles had been jailed for their part in the Ghadar movement. Singh attended a swadeshi school, became a voracious reader and chose atheism and Marxism as his beliefs. By the age of 16, he had chosen his vocation—to devote himself not just to the political but also to the economic independence of India's masses. There was no room in the revolutionary's life for marriage, but he valued love, beauty and poetry. "*Inqilab zindabad!*" was his slogan.

Ironically, he and his comrades' attacks often missed their target and they became most popular when they adopted more Gandhian methods, voluntarily taking the oppression of the state on to themselves. The bomb Singh threw into what is now Parliament was carefully aimed not to harm anyone. Then, and during the trial that

followed, he grew in stature. He and his comrades undertook hunger strikes in jail and endured the police's brutality. During the Lahore Conspiracy Case, in which he was accused of waging war against the king, Sukhdev, a co-accused, made a note of the false witnesses the State brought against them. Singing Urdu anthems to freedom, the revolutionaries used the trial to further their cause. When convicted, they faced death without fear. Indeed, Singh seemed never to doubt. That was his strength.

Nayar contrasts Singh's certainty with his father Kishen Singh's concern
SPRIT OF SACRIFICE: Bhagat Singh



as he tried to save his son from himself. It was he who filed a mercy petition without his son's permission and addressed the Congress session of 1931 to report Singh's last words to him. Nayar does not ignore the comrades who failed, in particular the sad figure of Hans Raj Vohra who turned State approver in the Lahore Conspiracy Case. Nayar concludes that Vohra was tricked into thinking his guru Sukhdev had given all their secrets away.

The tensions and sympathies between the revolutionaries and the Congress are carefully examined. Gandhi held that the "political murders" by the revolutionaries hindered India's passage to freedom. Singh argued that satyagraha should include physical as well as soul force. He had sympathisers in the Congress. Before his execution, he thanked Jawaharlal Nehru and Subhash Chandra Bose for the interest they had shown in his case. It was only with difficulty that Gandhi's draft resolution condemning Singh and his comrades' hanging, but also disassociating the Congress from all political violence, was passed by the Congress.

Nayar says the hanging of Singh and his comrades sounded the death knell for the British Raj. But they had aimed at more than the end of British rule. Perhaps independent India could have profited more if, Mandela-like, they had survived to usher in a new era. ■

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